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THE KNOWLEDGE MOBILIZERS OF THE EUROPEAN PARLIAMENT

-How political advisors to Members of European
Parliament mobilize knowledge in early policy
formation

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Abstract

This thesis examines how political advisors to Members of the European Parliament (MEPs) shape policies in the stages of policy formation, with a special emphasis on how they mobilize knowledge. Based on 14 semi-structured interviews with these political advisors, the study investigates both how they mobilize knowledge before reaching their MEPs. By using knowledge utilization theory, the study demonstrates that political advisors actively mobilize knowledge as a resource embedded in political, institutional, and relational contexts. Political advisors primarily mobilize knowledge by filtering through civil servants' reports, placing more or less trust in civil servants and using reports coming from outside of the European Parliament. The reasoning for doing so is based on the knowledge's alignment with political-strategic goals, its perceived institutional legitimacy, and the degree of trust in the knowledge provider. Informal networks and personal relationships with civil servants play a crucial role in determining which knowledge is used in policy-making. At the same time, advisors frequently draw on external actors, including NGOs and industry, when the ordinary knowledge paths do not work. This study contributes to the field by demonstrating that political advisors are mobilizing which knowledge influences EU policymaking in the end, despite not being elected representatives. This study gives policy implications regarding transparency in the lobbyist contacts between political advisors and lobbyists, and for more accountability measures in the mobilization of knowledge. Finally, the thesis points toward the need for further research on how informal networks and external actors influence the mobilization of expertise in EU policymaking processes.

Keywords: Political advisors, European Parliament, knowledge utilization, civil servants, knowledge mobilization.

AI declaration

AI has not been used to generate text. A spelling control program called Grammarly has been used to control and fix spelling and grammatical errors.

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1. Introduction

1.1. Problem formulation

Public skepticism toward the European Union (EU) has intensified over the last two decades, and many citizens perceive EU institutions as distant both politically and geographically (Statistica, 2025). At the same time, global challenges such as climate and energy crises, AI and digital protection, and global wars have increased demands for science-based policymaking capable of addressing increasingly complex problems. These developments have reinforced the importance of expertise and knowledge in policymaking processes (Blom, 2020). However, as previous literature shows, knowledge does not automatically guide political decisions, but knowledge must be actively mobilized by actors in order to become politically influential (Landry et al., 2003). Most knowledge produced within political systems never reaches final decision-making stages, meaning that it is continuously filtered throughout the policy process (Landry et al., 2003). Yet we still know relatively little about the actors who contribute to filtering and mobilizing this knowledge. If we do not know who filters and mobilizes expertise in policy formation processes, who do we hold accountable?

These questions are particularly important in the European Union, where policymaking operates within a multilayered governance system characterized by institutional complexity and a large administrative apparatus. Within this political environment, there has been an increase in non-elected officials working in the European Parliament, such as bureaucrats, civil servants, and political advisors. The last category, political advisors to Members of the European Parliament (MEPs), has become increasingly important in everyday political work. Political advisers are defined as politically appointed staff who work directly for elected representatives and provide support that combines policy analysis with partisan, strategic, and coordinating functions (Craft, 2013; Craft, 2015). They work with tasks such as drafting amendments, preparing negotiations, framing political issues, and coordinating political group positions, despite lacking formal decision-making authority (Dobbels & Neuhold, 2013; Winzen, 2011). Previous research describes political advisors as some of the primary actors to engage with legislative proposals at early stages and as actors possessing substantial autonomy in shaping these processes (Neunreither, 2002; Ruiter, 2019).

Although formally unelected, political advisors occupy a structurally influential position in policymaking, where they are often among the first actors to engage with legislative proposals (Neunreither, 2002; Ruiter, 2019). At this stage, knowledge from civil servants, research services, and external actors intersects with political strategy. Political advisors, therefore operate at the critical moment where knowledge is mobilized into politically actionable ideas (Neunreither, 2002; Pegan, 2022). These processes are especially important because the most decisive phase of EU policymaking often occurs early in policy formation, before policy proposals are formally presented (EPRS, 2021). In these stages, party positions are not yet fixed and negotiation mandates remain fluid, giving political advisors significant autonomy (Ruiter, 2022). This is where problem framings are created, amendments filtered, and expertise evaluated. Political advisors, therefore operate at a decisive, but often less visible, stage of policymaking.

Despite this, we still lack insight into how political advisors work with mobilizing expertise, how they balance political priorities with scientific evidence, and what shapes their understanding of which expertise is legitimate to use in policymaking. Addressing these gaps is essential for understanding who influences EU policymaking. Because much EU legislation concerns highly technical policy areas, the way expertise is handled during early policy formation becomes crucial. Without understanding how political advisors mobilize and filter expertise in these phases, we cannot fully understand how knowledge and politics are negotiated within the European Parliament or how evidence-based policymaking functions in practice.

This thesis therefore examines how political advisors in the European Parliament mobilize expertise during policy formation. More specifically, it investigates how political advisors mobilize knowledge, and what factors shape which forms of expertise become politically actionable. By focusing on political advisors as “knowledge mobilizers,” (Littoz-Monnet, 2017), the study contributes to previous research on expertise and EU governance by shifting attention from formal decision-making structures to the actors shaping how knowledge enters policymaking processes formally and informally.

1.2. Research aim

This study aims to examine how political advisors for Members of the European Parliament mobilize the knowledge that civil servants provide in the preparatory stages of policymaking. The study focuses on the everyday practices through which political advisors mobilize knowledge and actors providing the knowledge to find explanatory factors for how knowledge is filtered out or mobilized early in the legislative stage.

1.3. Research questions

This study has one overarching research question guiding the whole study. In Chapter 3.3., following the theory chapter, the research question will be developed into smaller research questions according to the theoretical framework. The following is the overarching research question:

How do political advisors who work for Members of the European Parliament mobilize knowledge from civil servants in the stages of policy formation?

1.4. Thesis structure

This chapter is structured into six different chapters. Chapter 1 introduces the research problem, research aim and question, and the relevance of studying political advisors as knowledge mobilizers in the European Parliament. Previous research is presented in Chapter 2 by reviewing expertise in policy EU processes and political advisors in modern governance and EU policymaking, and identifies the research gap that this paper will try to bridge. Then, Chapter 3 presents the theoretical framework of knowledge utilization theory and the concept of political advisors as knowledge mobilizers, as well as the analytical framework used in the study. The methodological approach is described in Chapter 4, including the qualitative interview design, sampling strategy, and coding process. Chapter 5 presents the empirical results and analysis of how political advisors mobilize knowledge in practice, consisting of subchapters derived from the codes in the analytical framework. Finally, Chapter 6 discusses the findings in relation to previous research and theory, before concluding the study and suggesting directions for future research.

2. Previous research

This chapter is structured in four parts. First, the chapter examines the existing literature on what we know about how knowledge affects policy-making in the European Parliament, followed by the role of political advisors in modern governance. Then the chapter analyzes how previous studies have conceptualized political advisors in the European Parliament, with particular focus on their functions as agenda setters and gatekeepers in policy formation. Lastly, the chapter reviews what previous literature tells us about how political advisors work with knowledge, and what we still do not know about this.

There is existing literature that dwells on the nature of political advisors nationwide and in the European Parliament. These consistently show that political advisors act as agenda-setters and gatekeepers, who influence legislative outcomes through different practices (Neunreither, 2002; Dobbels & Neuhold, 2013; Ruiter, 2019). Yet, as this literature review will show, important research gaps remain. We still know little about how political advisors work with knowledge in policy making and how they influence the mobilization of knowledge. These gaps motivate the closer empirical and theoretical examination that follows.

2.1. Knowledge and information in EU policy-making

Understanding the flow of knowledge and information within the EU institutions is central to understanding how knowledge and information enter and move through EU policymaking. It is not just a matter of basing policy proposals on science and knowledge; it is a whole apparatus based on influencing policy-making. This chapter only focuses on previous research on knowledge and information within EU policy-making. The reasoning behind this is the fact that no parliamentary system works the same with the influence of knowledge and information. Since the EU is a whole apparatus with its own divided levels of bureaucracy, this paper decided to only look into the previous literature on that to understand the specifics of the EU institutions and how they deal with knowledge (Blom, 2020).

Research on expertise in the EU has increasingly underlined that expertise is not neutral input simply guiding policymaking, but something closely connected to institutional and political structures (Abazi et al., 2020; Radaelli, 1999). Abazi et al. (2020) argue that EU governance has historically relied heavily on knowledge and technocratic legitimacy, which made

knowledge central to policymaking processes across EU institutions. At the same time, the authors demonstrate that knowledge within the EU is increasingly contested through debates concerning transparency and trust. Knowledge is therefore not simply accepted as objective knowledge put into policymaking, but is shaped through interpretations of it (Abazi et al., 2020).

The literature further highlights that expertise in EU policymaking operates through both formal and informal processes. Blom and Vanhoonacker (2020) show that knowledge is not only gained through institutional routines and formal legislative structures, but also through informal contact and coordination between actors. Policymaking is therefore understood as a process structured around the access of information and knowledge within organizations (Blom, 2020; Blom & Vanhoonacker, 2020). From this perspective, organizations function through continuous episodes of information processing in which actors determine what information is considered relevant, how it is communicated, and how it contributes to decision-making processes (Blom, 2020). This perspective is important for understanding knowledge and information in EU policymaking as more than scientific reports or technical expertise alone. Rather, knowledge and information are also informal exchanges, institutional understanding, stakeholder input, and politically interpreted information circulating between actors (Abazi et al., 2020). Informal coordination and networks therefore play an important role in the knowledge mobilization within EU institutions. Thus, it is not possible to deduce knowledge from information, or vice versa. The information gained from informal exchanges should also be viewed as knowledge claims because it is considered to be knowledge that affects the policy-making process (Abazi et al., 2020)..

Within this broader system, legislative and policy outcomes emerge through ongoing interaction between political and administrative actors, where knowledge must continuously be balanced with other priorities (Haas, 2004; Radaelli, 1999). Existing research has examined the interaction between these roles in informal exchanges and how expert advice is used within EU governance structures (Blom, 2020; Chalmers, 2014). However, these studies have paid less attention to the everyday actors mobilizing knowledge in practice. There remains a shortage of research on the actors who actively mobilize knowledge within EU policymaking processes. This paper rests on the assumption that political advisors might be actors central in this process,

as previous research have claimed them to be central figures in early policy formation (Ruiter, 2019), and the next chapters will be about previous literature on political advisors.

2.2. Situating political advisors in modern governance

We now know a lot about the knowledge processes in the EU governance structures. And it is time to examine the actors that might affect these knowledge processes. First, it is important to understand the role of political advisors. Much literature on political advisors is based on national parliamentary contexts. These studies provide an important analytical starting point for generally understanding political advisors, particularly their role as actors between politics and administration. This chapter section will underline the literature situating the political advisor's role in modern governance in different parliamentary systems.

Political advisors' employment is connected directly to the politician they work for, and their authority and reasoning derive from political loyalty and proximity to elected principals rather than from formal neutrality or administrative continuity (Craft, 2013; Craft, 2015; Shaw & Eichbaum, 2014). The different work tasks depend on the context they are working in, but a common determinant is underlined as working with policy advice and coordination within and outside of the party to be able to lay good policy proposals (Connaughton, 2015). The literature broadly agrees on the view that these actors occupy a structural position as politically appointed intermediaries between elected officials and administrative systems, sometimes being labeled as part politician and part bureaucrat (Hare, 2004).

Studies of national settings show that rather than acting just as providers of policy advice, political advisors manage political workloads, broker information flows, and coordinate tasks between politicians, bureaucrats, and external actors (Shaw & Eichbaum, 2014; Connaughton, 2015). Their role frequently involves filtering information in line with political objectives by being political gatekeepers (Ullström, 2011; Craft, 2013). Further highlighted is the hybrid nature of political advisors' work. Scholars generally agree that their tasks combine political judgement, such as assessing partisan priorities and coalition dynamics, with technically framed activities, such as drafting policy proposals, amendments, and briefing material. However, the boundary between political and technical work is widely regarded as blurred and difficult to disentangle in practice (Winzen, 2011; Craft, 2013). This hybridity is not seen as a defining feature of the role, enabling political advisors to translate political goals into politically

workable solutions. In summary, the literature theorizes political secretaries as hybrid political-administrative officials who work with information for the politicians they work for. However, as described in this chapter, political advisors seem to occupy a bigger role in governance than previously expected, with them having autonomy to work with gatekeeping access to politicians and coordinate the policy-work (Shaw & Eichbaum, 2014; Connaughton, 2015), but no study has tried to examine what their role in mobilizing knowledge is. If we know that they have this autonomy in policymaking, it is important to know how they work with mobilizing knowledge in order to understand what power they possess in choosing what knowledge gets into policymaking.

2.3. Situating political advisor in the European Parliament

Early studies of EU institutions did not explicitly distinguish between politically appointed staff and administrative officials. Nevertheless, they provide important insights into how influence is exercised within a fragmented institutional structure and show that EU bureaucrats exert substantial influence through expertise, institutional positioning, and informational control despite lacking electoral mandates (Page, 1997; Page, 2010). The increasing politicization and professionalization of the European Parliament, with an increase in the number of political and administrative staff, motivated later studies to more explicitly differentiate in staff categories. Research suggests systematic differences between political group staff and permanent secretariat officials in that political group staff prioritize partisan goals and ideological networks, whereas administrative officials emphasize procedural neutrality and institutional continuity (Egeberg et al., 2013).

In the European Parliament, where most legislative acts are concluded at first reading and shaped in committee and trilogue settings, agenda setting that political advisors do consists of political priorities (Laloux, 2020). Although the formal legislative process under the Treaty of Lisbon grants co-legislative powers to the Parliament and Council, most legislative files are concluded at first reading before and through committee work and informal interinstitutional negotiations, or trilogues (Laloux, 2020; EPRS, 2021). Committees, rapporteurs, and political groups shape amendments and compromises, while political advisors act as intermediaries between MEPs, groups, and committees, translating technical expertise from civil servants into politically feasible positions (Ruiter, 2019; Panke & Haubrich-Seco, 2022). In these policy

formation processes political advisors seem to have an important role in shaping legislative outcomes (Leino-Sandberg, 2021; Hillebrandt & Leino-Sandberg, 2021; Ruiter 2019). Their embeddedness in overlapping formal and informal networks, provides them with privileged access to information and networks, privileging certain interests, such as lobbyists or other interest groups, in agenda-setting processes (Neunreither, 2002; Pegan, 2022; Albareda et al., 2023).

In a PHD dissertation, this early autonomy is investigated to uncover varying forms of mandates (Ruiter, 2019). Autonomy for political advisors is shown to be highest in early policy formation stages, when proposals are not yet made, party positions are not yet consolidated and MEP instructions remain broad. As negotiation mandates formalize and partisan lines solidify, advisers' discretionary space narrows (Ruiter, 2019; Ruiter, 2022:). This temporal dynamic aligns with broader findings that influence in EU lawmaking is concentrated in early phases, particularly in committee work and informal trilogues, where substantive compromises are often settled before plenary votes (Laloux, 2020; Hillebrandt & Leino-Sandberg, 2021; Laloux, 2020), but adds another perspective that political advisors are particularly important in this phase.

Agenda-setting, however, also entails exclusion. The autonomy that enables political advisors to structure what is placed on the agenda simultaneously positions them as gatekeepers. In a complex legislative environment, MEPs depend heavily on staff to structure their informational landscape (Neunreither, 2002; Pegan, 2022). This reliance allows political advisors to assess ideological trade-offs and structure compromise options before formal positions are articulated (Ruiter, 2019).

While Ruiter (2019) demonstrates that advisors occupy degrees of autonomy depending on institutional and contextual conditions, the analysis primarily focuses on the scope and conditions of this rather than the micro-level processes through which advisors work and create certain concrete political actions. In other words, we know that political advisors have a certain position in the European Parliament that lets them act politically, but we know less about how they work with this position and what guides them in their political action. This study builds on these insights but shifts the analytical focus from the existence of autonomy for political advisors to their practical tools. It asks how political advisors mobilize politically viable

positions in policy formation. By doing so, it moves beyond a structural understanding of advisory roles and instead examines the toolbox and the actual political action they take.

Taken together, the literature portrays political advisors in the European Parliament as agenda setters and gatekeepers who shape policy-making early. Considering the early-stage concentration of influence described in the introduction, this is not only interesting to look at from an organizational standpoint but also from a democratic perspective. If substantive political trade-offs are done before committee and trilogue meetings, and if political advisors play a central role in shaping negotiation mandates and compromise texts, then understanding this process becomes a democratic essential. While research demonstrates the fact that they play a role in agenda setting and gatekeeping, less attention has been paid to how they themselves filter and decide an opinion.

2.4. Summarizing the research gap

Taken together, the reviewed literature demonstrates that expertise and knowledge are central to EU policymaking, while its influence is shaped and contested by institutional structures and norms (Radaelli, 1999; Abazi et al., 2020; Blom, 2020). Existing research has shown how knowledge circulates through both formal and informal processes, and how expertise is accessed in both formal and informal networks (Blom & Vanhoonacker, 2020). However, despite increasing attention to expertise in EU governance, there remains a gap regarding how actors mobilize expertise in practice.

At the same time, the literature on political advisors consistently portrays them as influential actors within the European Parliament. Political advisors are described as agenda-setters and gatekeepers who shape policymaking through their work and information control, particularly during policy formation (Neunreither, 2002; Dobbels & Neuhold, 2013; Ruiter, 2019). Existing studies indicate that political advisors occupy a position that gives them significant influence over shaping policies (Neunreither, 2002), meaning that they hold a position that could mean that they get to shape which knowledge is mobilized in EU governance. Despite this, less attention has been paid to how political advisors practically work with knowledge in their everyday activities. While previous research demonstrates that political advisors influence policymaking and act as filters of information, there is still limited understanding of how they mobilize expertise in practice. This gap is important because political advisors operate in

influential but often less visible positions within the policymaking process, particularly in phases of policy formation where further directions are shaped before formal political decisions are made. Understanding how advisors mobilize expertise is therefore not only relevant from an organizational perspective, but also from a democratic and accountability perspective, since these processes influence which forms of knowledge become politically relevant and whose perspectives are included in policymaking. This study addresses this gap by examining political advisors as actors mobilizing knowledge within the European Parliament. The focus is on how knowledge is mobilized into political action during policy formation, to shed light on this less visible group.

3. Theory and concepts

This chapter develops a theoretical framework used to analyze the empirical material, and to understand how political advisors to MEPs mobilize knowledge in policy making. The chapter is divided into three parts. A theoretical framework for knowledge utilization is presented to understand how knowledge is mobilized in policymaking processes and to understand what role political advisors have in this process. Some limitations and definitions are made here to understand the empirical material better. Then, the chapter outlines how these perspectives together guide the operationalization of the research questions and create a theoretical framework. Lastly, the theoretical contributions and limitations are presented.

3.1. Knowledge utilization theory and knowledge mobilization in policymaking

Knowledge utilization theory conceptualizes the use of knowledge as selective rather than something that guides the whole process (Landry et al., 2003). It rests on the assumption that most knowledge from research reports, epistemic communities or officials never reaches the final stage, meaning that it has to be filtered away somewhere in the process (Landry et al., 2003). The theory challenges the assumption that science and knowledge increasingly guide policy impact; instead, knowledge utilization depends on political processes and the interaction between knowledge producers and knowledge users (Landry et al., 2003).

Research on organizational knowledge processes reinforces this view. Mohaghegh et al. (2024) conceptualize utilization of knowledge as the transformative moment in which knowledge becomes action in organizations. Knowledge only produces value when translated into action, and translation occurs only through actors who choose to mobilize knowledge under specific conditions (Mohaghegh et al., 2024; Blom, 2020). Knowledge has no inherent effect without such mobilization, which underscores that its significance is relational and actor-dependent. Selection is seen as something discursive, and that knowledge claims are only accepted when they resonate with dominant narratives and established problem definitions (Christensen, 2023; Esguerra, 2024). Haas's (1992) concept of epistemic communities similarly emphasizes that expert authority depends on shared understandings and institutional recognition, although Christensen (2023) specifies the mechanisms through which institutions condition influence by highlighting administrative position and role expectations. Knowledge utilization theory

emphasizes that expertise is not simply transmitted and then used in policymaking but is mobilized depending on decision-makers' needs, beliefs, and strategic considerations (Landry et al., 2003; Blom, 2020).

Here, the concept of "knowledge mobilizers" comes in. Knowledge mobilizers are the actors who mobilize expert knowledge for the policy process (Landry et al., 2003; Littoz-Monnet, 2017). In the knowledge chain, meaning the process through which knowledge moves from its production by epistemic communities, researchers, or institutions, through mobilization to its eventual use in policymaking (Haas, 1992; Littoz-Monnet, 2017), the knowledge mobilizers have a crucial role in receiving knowledge from the producers into political action. For this study, political advisors are understood as knowledge mobilizers who mobilize knowledge, and this is the process that will be studied in order to understand how they do it. The understanding that political advisors themselves are actors that help shape policy-making (Ruiter, 2019) is central to this study and to understanding how they themselves are actors that mobilize expert knowledge.

One could use other definitions to define these actors that affect the process, such as knowledge utilizers (Landry et al., 2003). However, this paper chooses to define the political advisors as mobilizers, to put the fact that the use of knowledge in policy-making is an actor-driven process to meet a goal (Mohaghegh et al. 2024). The choice of the concept "knowledge mobilizers (Littoz-Monnet, 2017) underlines the fact that the mobilizer mobilizes when their knowledge-based preferences align with different conditions (Christensen, 2023). They mobilize knowledge through different mechanisms. Three mechanisms appear in the material that can describe the reasoning behind how actors mobilize knowledge. First, the mobilizer of knowledge mobilizes knowledge strategically so that it fits into the strategic goals of their institution or organization (Landry et al., 2003). Secondly, the mobilizer mobilizes knowledge to strengthen the legitimacy of their institution or organization according to set rules or norms of the institution or organization (Landry et al., 2003). Third, the individual degree of trust and the relationship between the mobilizer of knowledge and the provider of knowledge affect how much the knowledge mobilizer mobilizes the knowledge (Mohaghegh et al., 2024). Here comes a longer description of the codes, that constitutes what to look for in the empirical material.

3.3. Operationalization of the theoretical framework

Based on the set frames of knowledge utilization, this study has adopted a theoretical framework for looking through the empirical material with the set frames in mind. Based on the above developed theoretical framework, the study develops three analytical dimensions of knowledge mobilization: political-strategic fit, institutional legitimacy and norms, and relational trust. These dimensions function both as analytical codes in the coding of the empirical material, which is more thoroughly described in chapter 4.2., and also as the basis for the interview questions used in the empirical investigation, which is more developed in 4.1.2. . Under each analytical code, some more in-depth questions are provided. These are analytically driven questions that help in the coding process to look at the material and break down the three codes. These in-depth questions are based on the assumptions of what may come up in the empirical material regarding each code.

3.3.1. Operationalization of “Fit into political-strategic goals”

Knowledge utilization theory suggests that actors selectively use knowledge that aligns with their goals and decision-making needs, in a reasoning called “users’ organizational contextual factors” (Landry et al., 2003, p.203). This is developed into more practical goals by linking the “users’ organizational contextual factors” to the organization’s strategic goals itself (Mohaghehegh et al, 2024). In the context of European Parliament, this suggests that political advisors mobilize expertise according to partisan priorities and strategies. If it fits their “organization’s strategic goals”, knowledge is to be mobilized. This puts political advisors in a position where they are not merely receivers of expertise, but intermediaries who mobilize expertise into their strategic goals compatible with party agendas.

When analyzing the empirical material, the questions for this code asked are:

- Do the political advisor explain that they ever used knowledge provided to strengthen their political or strategical argument? Has the political advisors have ignored knowledge because it did not fit with their strategy?
- Does it seem like strategy is a guiding factor for political advisors to mobilize knowledge. Which strategies do they explain?

3.2.2. Operationalization of “Institutional legitimacy and norms”

Knowledge utilization theory suggests that whether actors mobilize expertise depends on context, institutional structures, and the perceived legitimacy of knowledge claims (Landry et al., 2003). Similarly, Mohaghegh et al. (2024) argue that knowledge becomes influential only when actors mobilize it in ways that are considered relevant and actionable within organizational settings. Expertise therefore gains influence not automatically, but when it is recognized as legitimate within an institutional context. Legitimacy depends on the different norms and values that is placed on the knowledge, depending on the institutional context, which in this case can be viewed both as the institutional context of the Parliament or the institutional context that is the political party group the political advisor is working for.

Political advisors may mobilize expertise not only because it aligns with strategic goals, as the first code lays it out to be, but because it is perceived as institutionally appropriate and credible in the different institutional contexts they are in. Different knowledge claims coming from different parliamentary civil servants, legal services, or external or internal organizations may be regarded as particularly legitimate due to their recognized roles (Christensen, 2023). Institutional legitimacy and norms therefore shapes both which sources are trusted and how knowledge is integrated into policymaking processes (Blom, 2020).

This code examines whether political advisors mobilize knowledge institutional legitimacy and norms. When analyzing the empirical material, the questions for this code asked are:

- Do political advisors explain that they mobilize expertise because it is perceived as institutionally credible or legitimate in the Parliament? Or do they mean that they mobilize expertise because it is perceived as credible or legitimate within their own political party group?
- How do political advisors rely on knowledge to reinforce procedural legitimacy or credibility in policymaking?

3.2.3. Operationalization of “Relational trust”

Knowledge utilization theory highlights that expertise is more likely to be mobilized when relationships between knowledge producers and users are characterized by interaction and trust (Landry et al., 2003). Rather than viewing knowledge use as a neutral process of evidence uptake, Landry et al. (2003) emphasize that the interaction between actors shape whether

expertise is gained and used. Similarly, Mohaghegh et al. (2024) conceptualize knowledge utilization as an actor-driven process in which expertise gains influence through communication and informality. This suggests that trust in expertise is often relational and socially embedded, and in the context of the European Parliament would mean that through the formal and informal networks where political advisors meet different actors they would gain different quantity and quality of expertise depending on the relationship and trust between the actors. This is one reason why knowledge claims both gained formally and informally is important for this study. This study will look at both how political advisors mobilize knowledge coming from scientific studies and informal information gained in informal interactions. Christensen (2023) argues that expert influence depends not only on knowledge itself but also on access to decision-makers, relationships between actors, and the informal positioning of expertise within policymaking processes. Communication and repeated interaction between policymakers and knowledge providers strongly shape whether expertise is mobilized (Oliver et al., 2014; Head, 2015; Christensen 202). Expertise can therefore be seen as more trusted and mobilized because it was gained through informal relationships and repeated collaboration between actors, rather than exclusively through formal institutional channels. It does not matter whether the knowledge is gained formally or informally, the actor mobilizing it will mobilize it according to their set of priorities, no matter what.

This perspective is especially relevant to research in an environment such as the European Parliament. The political advisors may rely more on knowledge and information gained from actors they know informally, have worked with repeatedly in or outside of the Parliament, or perceive as trustworthy. Informal exchanges with parliamentary civil servants, committee staff, political group colleagues, and external stakeholders may therefore shape which expertise is considered reliable and politically usable. Trust can be a mechanism for reducing uncertainty and efficiently navigating complex legislative processes. Political advisors may develop recurring patterns of cooperation with particular actors, creating informal networks of expertise that complement formal institutional structures. Knowledge thereby becomes influential not only because of authority and because it fits strategic goals, but also because actors trust the individuals providing it.

This code examines how interpersonal relationships, informal coordination, and repeated interaction shape the mobilization of expertise in the European Parliament.

When analyzing the empirical material, the questions for this code are:

- Do political advisors explain mobilizing expertise because they trust the individual actor providing it?
- Will repeated collaboration or informal relationships shape which knowledge is considered reliable by the political advisors?
- How do the political advisors describe that personal networks influence how expertise is mobilized?
- Is knowledge shared or trusted through informal rather than formal channels? How do political advisors describe this?

3.2.4. Other codes for mobilizing of knowledge

Although the theoretical framework is deductive and categories are theoretically derived, the analysis remains open to deviations. If respondents describe mobilizing practices that do not align with theoretical expectations, these are coded separately, treated as analytically meaningful to develop theory and will be discussed (Tracy, 2010).

3.3. Theoretical limitations and contributions

This thesis contributes to existing research by better understanding how political advisors in the European Parliament mobilize expertise. Knowledge utilization theory explains how expertise is mobilized, emphasizing that knowledge rarely influences policy automatically but is shaped by different factors (Landry et al., 2003; Mohaghegh et al., 2024). Research in this field further demonstrates that knowledge can serve multiple purposes beyond just bringing in science-based policy-making, including strategic mobilizing, where knowledge is used to support predetermined political positions or reinforce legitimacy (Mohaghegh et al., 2024). Whilst an important perspective to understand the political advisor's reasoning behind mobilizing certain knowledge, knowledge utilization provides limited explanations for why some forms of expertise become legitimate or trusted within institutional environments. That is why this paper focuses on explaining the process and understanding political advisors as knowledge mobilizers.

The main theoretical contribution of this thesis is therefore to test the theoretical framework on a new group of actors, and to test the assumption that these are knowledge mobilizers. Also, to test the theoretical assumptions and see if there are any other perspectives that the theoretical framework has missed in the “others” section.

4. Method and methodology

This chapter presents the methodological approach and research design of the study. Since the thesis examines how political advisors mobilize knowledge within the European Parliament, a qualitative research design was chosen to capture political advisors' recollections. This choice is described in the following chapter. This chapter also describes the selection of respondents, the data collection process and presents the analytical strategy and reflects on methodological questions.

4.1. Data collection

This subchapter focuses on the data collection process of the empirical material and describes different methodological choices made in relation to the data collection process.

4.1.1 Sampling selection and strategy

This study adopts a qualitative research design based on semi-structured interviews with political advisors currently employed by Members of the European Parliament (MEPs). The choice of political advisors as the study objects for this study is well-motivated in the previous research chapter. In short, this is an understudied group of power in the European Parliament, who, according to previous studies, possess a lot of gatekeeping power in policy formation (Leino-Sandberg, 2021; Hillebrandt & Leino-Sandberg, 2021). Therefore, there is reason to believe that they also have a lot of power in choosing which knowledge gets brought to the table in policy making and therefore affects policy making. The choice to interview this study group is, as laid down in the previous research chapter, a conscious choice to shed light on this understudied group.

A qualitative approach is appropriate given the study's focus on understanding how phenomena are described and experienced. As Marshall and Rossman (2016, p. 180) note, qualitative research seeks "to understand phenomena from the participants' perspectives and to explore and discover, in depth and in context, what may have been missed when studies were conducted with predetermined assumptions." Capturing the perspectives of political advisors is therefore essential for addressing the research questions.

This study also only interviews political advisors employed by the MEPs, and not the political party groups' political advisors. During some of the interviews, the party group's political advisors were brought up as those creating reports and those mostly conducting research on the implications of policy proposals. This only confirmed the choice in not interviewing them, as the aim of the study is to understand not the research process of the staff in itself, but the filtering process that the political advisors have in the process with their MEP. The choice to only interview political advisors who work for MEP is purposeful to my research question, as they only work closely with one MEP and work directly with filtering for one MEP.

A purposive sampling strategy was employed to identify political advisors working for MEPs (Bryman, 2012). This means that I first contacted all the e-mails I could find to all the political advisors in the European Parliament. When this did not result in a satisfactory number of interviews, a snowball sampling strategy was also utilized. Respondents were asked to recommend colleagues who might be willing to participate, thereby expanding the pool of interviewees and facilitating greater diversity in political group affiliations (Marshall and Rossman, 2016).

The European Parliament is composed of eight political groups, which bring together national parties and coalitions from across the political spectrum. These groups include: the Group of the European People's Party (EPP), representing conservatives and Christian democrats; the Progressive Alliance of Socialists and Democrats (S&D), representing social democrats and democratic socialists; the Patriots for Europe Group (Patriots), representing nationalist positions; the European Conservatives and Reformists Group (ECR), representing conservatives and nationalists; Renew Europe (Renew), representing liberal and centrist positions; the Greens/European Free Alliance (Greens/EFA), representing ecological, pirate, and independent perspectives; The Left (GUE/NGL), representing socialist and left-wing positions; and the Europe of Sovereign Nations Group (Sovereigns), representing nationalist perspectives.

The initial goal was to conduct approximately 16 interviews, ideally including two advisors from each political group. However, in total, 14 political advisors were interviewed: one from

EPP, three from S&D, one from ECR, five from Renew, and four from the Greens/EFA. Although the original target was not fully achieved, the sample includes advisors from several politically influential groups and reflects variation in ideological positioning and committee assignments. This diversity is analytically valuable, as trust in civil servants and knowledge may differ across political groups and policy domains.

While variation in group affiliation is theoretically important, given that political ideology may shape political advisors' perspectives, this study does not aim to produce statistically generalizable findings. Instead, it seeks to provide in-depth insights into the practices and experiences of political advisors within the European Parliament.

4.1.2. Interviews and interview guide

The interviews follow a semi-structured design with a core set of guiding questions and space for follow-up questions. This format is well-suited to uncover how political advisors describe their mobilization in relation to the theoretical framework.

All interviews were audio-recorded with consent. A fieldwork stay at the European Parliament in Brussels was conducted for a week in March 2026, supported by a scholarship. Both digital and in-person interviews were conducted to ensure participation from those who could not meet me. In-person interviews offered richer detail and greater trust (Marshall and Rossman, 2016), in that more follow-up questions and more informal information were given, e.g., one participant showed me e-mails related to the topics and another one showed me a report they did for their MEP to demonstrate how they used research from the European Union Research Service in their work. Digital interviews enabled greater outreach and allowed flexibility, but the empirical material was less detailed. In total, nine interviews were digital, and five were in-person.

After about ten interviews, I considered the empirical findings to be made and felt that the material was rather saturated, meaning that most of the respondents' answers afterwards were more treated as confirmation interviews to the previous interviews, as almost everyone gave a similar recollection.

The interview guide was developed in relation to the theoretical framework, following a deductive approach with the purpose of writing questions that are connected to the theory and can support the results. An important aspect is that many of the questions asked were open ended questions so that they could give practical examples from their work whenever, which a lot of the respondents did. These examples have been a key part of the analysis. Here is the interview guide, together with explanations and a link to the theory:

The introductory questions

These questions had the purpose of establishing their role and autonomy:

1. *How long have you worked as a political advisor in the European Parliament?*
2. *What are your tasks and responsibilities in the process when you make policy proposals and gather information to make policy proposals? What can you decide and do in this process without consulting your MEP?*

Gaining expertise from civil servants and the informal/formal relationship:

To place them in the early legislative phases and let them begin to reflect on their position in early policy-making, the following question was asked, related to theory via Institutional legitimacy and norm. This question is

3. *Think about a committee you work in. How does a usual trialogue meeting work? And how do you prepare before trialogue meetings and negotiations?*

To understand their formal and informal relationship with civil servants and what shapes them to mobilize knowledge based on this, the following questions were asked in relation to the theory via *Relational trust*:

4. *Reflect upon the last time you had contact with civil servants providing scientific, legal, technical, procedural help/information. What type of basis or expertise did this civil servant contribute with? Did you have trust in this civil servant? Why or why not?*
5. *Is there any particular civil servant that they usually think is especially good? What is it that makes that person especially good in these contexts? Someone you listen to a little more carefully? Is there someone you think is less good and what makes that*

person less good?

Follow up: Would a civil servants coming from your country or national context better give you knowledge? A civil servant who have worked longer in the Parliament? A civil servant who gives information that confirms your political priorities?

Trust in knowledge and strategic mobilizing

The following questions were asked to examine the mobilizing process and plausible explanations, with the link to all the codes in the theory:

6. When you receive input, what is it that you focus on? What is it that you think is important? What do you take with you? And what is it that determines what you take with you?
7. How do you decide what information to pass on to your MEP. What trade-offs do you make, if any?

Examining the mobilizing process, especially in relation to theory via *Strategic goals*:

8. Can you remember a situation where civil servant expertise and your party group's political line did not completely align? How did you relate to that information in the design of the policy proposal? What considerations guided you?

Outside perspective

Asking them to think outside of their own perspective, and let them speculate about how their colleagues behave, in relation to theory via *Institutional legitimacy and norms*:

9. Do you think other political advisors work in the same way as you do, i.e., that they make the same trade-offs as you do and do they listen particularly carefully to the same civil servants? If not, how do they do these processes?

Concluding

With the purpose of giving them a second chance to answer, if any of the questions triggered a response to another question:

10. Now that I have asked you all the questions, is there anything you want to add as an answer for another question?

4.1.3. Justifications and limitations of chosen design

Interview-based research is well-suited to understanding how the political advisors describe how they work, which is suitable for understanding the research questions. However, interviews should be understood as interactionally produced accounts rather than direct representations of behavior or “objective reality” (Rapley, 2001). They capture participants’ sense-making processes rather than observable practices. This means that the interview study-based approach will not capture the whole picture of knowledge utilization at the European Parliament, but rather how the political advisors are resonating around it. Therefore, at the stage of policy formation, document analysis of materials from meetings and pre-meetings was considered a plausible methodological approach. Such documents could provide valuable insights into formal structures and decision-making processes. In the context of EU policymaking, the primary documents available are the formal minutes from committee triologue meetings. However, these minutes typically contain only agenda items and formal decisions, offering little insight into the policy formation and preparatory work. And as established, the preparatory work is the process where political advisors are the most influential in shaping policy (Ruiter, 2019; Ruiter, 2022).

Moreover, it is important to note that political advisors do not make formal decisions; these are taken by Members of the European Parliament (MEPs). Political advisors instead prepare before formal decisions are made, which raises the analytical question of what information is filtered before reaching the formal level where written documents could be found. A document-based approach would therefore require access to internal materials such as advisors’ notes, briefings, or preparatory documents in order to capture the process of how they work with mobilizing knowledge.

In practice, gaining access to such materials proved difficult. During interviews, it became clear that even when political advisors were willing to share documents, such as briefings or reports

used in preparatory work, it was very limited. For instance, when a respondent showed their notes and briefings, they made it clear that no photographs could be taken, and only brief handwritten notes to remember what they showed were permitted. As a result, any documentation collected in this way remained fragmentary and unable to be analyzed properly.

Even if such materials could be systematically accessed, they would still provide only a partial picture. Informal negotiations, taking place through conversations, emails, and personal relationships, are central to the work of political advisors but are rarely documented. As Ullström (2011) argues, everyday political work and informal coordination mechanisms are seldom recorded, and early-stage negotiations are both undocumented and typically inaccessible to researchers. A document study would therefore be insufficient for capturing the informal and interpretive dimensions that are central to this study.

An alternative approach could have been ethnographic participant observation. Observing meetings and negotiations can provide valuable insights into everyday interactions (Marshall & Rossman, 2016). However, this approach also presents significant challenges in the context of the European Parliament, particularly in terms of gaining access to closed negotiations and informal settings where much of the political advisors' work takes place. The question of access is further debated in the discussion sub-chapter. Furthermore, observation alone would offer limited insight into how actors themselves understand and reflect on their roles and practices within the civil service. In sum, an interview study is shown to be the best alternative to understand the sense-making of political advisors. By conducting 14 semi-structured interviews with political advisors working in the European Parliament, the study is able to capture detailed accounts of how knowledge is mobilized in early policymaking. This type of qualitative material provides insight into processes that are otherwise difficult to observe directly, but it also means that findings rely on how respondents describe and reflect on their work (Marshall & Rossman, 2016; Rapley, 2001). The use of semi-structured interviews is therefore important, as it allows respondents to explain concrete situations, such as negotiations or interactions with civil servants, rather than only giving generalized statements.

4.2. Transcription and coding

Microsoft Word's transcription tool was used to transcribe all the interviews, and afterwards the material was double-checked with the recordings. The transcription tool was a way of saving time on the transcription process, which otherwise would be a time-consuming process.

All transcripts were read and coded using the analytical codes presented in the Theory and Concepts chapter. The codes were organized in an Excel spreadsheet and later summarized in a separate spreadsheet to support comparison across interviews. The coding process was guided by the in-depth questions derived from the theoretical framework and whenever respondents answered these in-depth questions, it was put into the spreadsheet under the relevant overarching code in the spreadsheet. This made it easier to analyze the empirical material. Empirical material that did not fit within the predetermined codes was also coded and treated as additional themes emerging from the interviews.

The analysis builds on a theoretically analytical framework, where the empirical material is analyzed through the three codes of political-strategic fit, institutional legitimacy and norms, and relational trust. Applying these codes across all interviews creates a structured way of comparing responses, while still allowing space for differences between respondents and for findings that do not fully align with the theoretical expectations. In this sense, the study combines a deductive approach with sensitivity to variation in the material, which strengthens the connection between theory and empirical analysis (Coffey & Atkinson, 1996; Silverman, 2006).

4.3. Methodological discussion

This subchapter discusses the methodological strengths and limitations of the study. It discusses the challenges of interviewing political advisors as a political elite, ethical considerations, and issues related to gaining access to the European Parliament. The discussion also considers how the methodological choices affect the study's credibility, transparency, and analytical contribution.

4.3.1. Interviewing a “political elite”

Political advisors should be understood as part of a political elite, defined as individuals occupying positions of authority or influence within political institutions (Giddens et al., 1974 in Ullström, 2011). Interviewing such actors presents specific methodological challenges, as

they are used to working with media and the strategies coming with that, which may influence how they present their work and motivations during interviews (Ullström, 2011). To be well prepared for this, the interview guide relied on open-ended questions with follow-up questions, but still grounded in theory, which let the respondents speak freely, making the interview setting feel more like a discussion than a strict interview (Marshall & Rossman, 2016). The empirical material does not seem to have fallen for these methodological problems, and the political advisors seem to have answered all the questions without giving vague answers

Preparation is also important here, as Lilleker (2003) underlines one might need a higher number of interviews to define what kind of questions work with the “political elite” and to exercise in this setting. The 14 interviews ensured this kind of quantity and allowed me to tweak the way the questions were asked without taking away anything important and still ensuring analytically comparable answers.

4.2.3. Ethical considerations

Participants received detailed information about the study’s purpose, methods, confidentiality measures, and their right to withdraw at any time before the interviews began. During the interviews, I asked them for their agreement on these rules as well as permission to record. Given the fact that the interviews are about their ongoing work situation, anonymity is provided in the paper. Only their European Party Group is discussed in the analysis, as there are theoretical reasons why this could be analytically important. Which MEP they work for is not analytically important and would revoke the anonymity, so this is removed from the transcriptions as well. Although the country of origin could be an analytically important factor due to differences in work culture and collaboration at work, this study does not look too much into that. Following Winzen (2020), interview quantity is treated as an ethical consideration, as including respondents from multiple political groups and many from each contribute to anonymity and reduce the risk of individual identification. 14 respondents are enough to ensure anonymity. Since I had contacts that provided contact ways for me, a part of the ethical considerations process was also to ensure that these contacts could not decode their contacts. These snowball contacts were not that many people, and by ensuring that there is more than one respondent from all the political party groups (except for one, but that respondent’s

participation was not ensured via a contact), the contacts have no way of figuring out the respondents' identities. Additionally, the contacts do not know if I interviewed their contacts.

Ethical judgment was exercised continuously throughout the interview process, particularly in cases where respondents refrained from sharing information due to party loyalty or political sensitivity. The respondents were informed beforehand that they could withdraw their answers or end the interview. However, as that was not the case in any of the interviews, the refusals to answer or sensitivity are treated as analytically meaningful.

4.2.4. The problem with access

The e-mails of the political advisors are usually not published online, some on the national parties' webpages, which led me down a path of looking at webpages in languages I do not speak to try to translate and decode contact ways. When that did not work, I contacted the European Parliament's service, who refused to give me the e-mail addresses. In the end, I figured out that the format for the e-mail addresses was either "name.surname@europarl.europa.eu" or name.surname@ep.europa.eu. I ended up sending a lot of e-mail using this format.

Access to parliament was a particular problem. Due to the strict rules on entering the European Parliament, a lot of time had to be put into figuring out how to be allowed to enter to hold interviews, which was not important for my analysis but to get an understanding of the work environment. The European Parliament Services did not grant me access, as they only grant special access to journalists or researchers. In the end, a contact helped me with a staff invite for the whole week, which resulted in me being able to enter the European Parliament with the accompaniment of staff.

5. Results and analysis

All 14 conducted interviews touch upon the predetermined themes presented in Chapter 3 in some way. In this chapter, one of the codes will be touched upon in each individual chapter. Following, the deviations will be presented as additional codes that were not presented in the theoretical framework. These are just briefly explained in the last chapter, and are treated as subjects for future research projects.

5.1. The mobilizing role of a political advisor in the EP

Since the world of a political advisor is unknown to many, this sub-chapter will first lay a foundation for understanding how political advisors themselves work with mobilizing knowledge. We know that political advisors have a lot of power in early legislative work (Ruiter, 2019), but the question of how they work with the mobilizing of knowledge is less known. This is a question that needs to be answered before understanding their reasoning behind the process.

The interviews show that political advisors in the European Parliament act as mediators between civil servants and political decision-makers. Several respondents describe their mobilizing role as political advisors as one of filtering information. As one explains:

So how I consider my job is to be like a filter, to be a first filter [...] and first we have to filter what is relevant, what is useful and what can be used for us. [...] Second, we share the information with a proposition on what we think is good and the right way, or not, to our MEP, which creates a discussion with our MEP. (Interview 7, S&D)

This description illustrates how filtering constitutes a core task in the political advisor's daily work. The advisor does not simply pass on information but evaluates relevance and usability before presenting it to the MEP. In practice, this filtering is embedded in everyday legislative routines. Political advisors describe how they begin by assessing relevance "[...] to look what's on the committee meeting topic, whether it's of interest for your MEP or not" before preparing notes and interventions (Interview 2, EPP), indicating that they filter before meetings.

They also actively engage with multiple sources of expertise: “I do like to read one or two industry rapports, but also a strong focus on NGO statements, and based on that, I do suggestions for amendments [...] explaining what the law is about, why we think this amendment would be important” (Interview 9, Greens). These accounts illustrate how advisors work with different knowledge sources, not just the ones provided by the institutions’ research services or their civil servants.

They continue to describe their role as affected by different working routines and cultures. One respondent emphasizes that due to particularly high time pressure and information overload, they need to mobilize and filter information because their role is about “[...] giving my MEP as little information as possible [...] really the necessary thing is not to give them an information overload or to confuse them,” and further explains that their main task in reading scientific and civil servants’ reports is to identify “what is the core message, what is the one side arguing, what is the other side arguing” (Interview 14, Renew). Another respondent describes their job process as:

That I kind of identify what is important to us. We work a lot with priorities so that we do not prioritize everything in the committees, but we have a fairly clear idea of what we should spend our time on or I should spend my time on, so then I identify which tasks are important. [...] I make sure she has what she needs to be well-informed about it [...] I have quite a large freedom in preparations. That is, in the negotiations, I kind of look at the technical level, what is good, what is not good. (Interview 8, S&D)

Another political advisor continues by also describing this kind of gatekeeping function in the early policy making: “If we are negotiating [...] I am the one proposing to her what our line should be[...]” (Interview 14, Renew). This further illustrates that political advisors look through all the material to determine what is important and not, further underlining their gatekeeping and autonomous function in early policymaking.

Finally, the degree of autonomy in the mobilizing process seems to vary depending on the political sensitivity of the issue. While advisors may act independently, others emphasize that

when they prepare reports and briefing, “when there is something sensitive, I always have to seek my MEP’s approval [...] because it's their name under these amendments” (Interview 5, ECR).

This reflects the conditional nature of political advisors where autonomy is higher in routine or technical matters and can be more constrained when political stakes increase. Another respondent also underlines that they do not have that much autonomy due to them being fairly new to the job, and points out that there can be a difference between new and experienced political advisors

[...] we have some colleagues who have been with the MEP for a longer time. Since the last mandate. So, they already know what the MEP’s general direction is and what the MEP emphasizes. Like if you have more experience, I think you don't need to consult them in the early stage. (Interview 2, EPP)

This perspective, however, seems to vary a bit depending on which party group. It seems to be mostly the respondents from ECR and EPP who do not mean that they have that much autonomy, while the other respondents seem to explain a work culture of autonomy, as described above. This is important to the rest of the analysis as well because depending on how much experience the political advisor has, how much they work with politically sensitive topics or in a European party group that provides less autonomy to their political advisors, they might have different experiences in mobilizing knowledge. This is, however, not a reason to view the study’s conclusions as non-generalizable, but just to show that some work cultures allow more or less autonomy to their political advisors which could provide different views on the issue.

In summary, political advisors in the European Parliament act as key actors who actively mobilize information from reports and other knowledge sources in many different ways before it reaches their MEPs. They filter through information’s relevance before giving it to MEPs and before going into negotiations. This process is done with different levels of autonomy given to them by their MEP, that needs to be further examined. The mobilizing process is shown to be shaped by priorities that this paper will dive into these factors in the next chapter.

5.2. Strategic mobilizing of knowledge

Now that we have the foundation for understanding the role of a political advisor in the European Parliament, this paper will go into the results and analysis of the codification of the empirical material. The following chapters aim at understanding how political advisors mobilize knowledge according to set strategies for their organization (Mohaghegh et al, 2024).

The identified strategies in this chapter are partisan strategic goals (which in this chapter is identified as the partisan strategic goals from the national political party, the European political party group and/or the individual MEP), strategies to make the material technical usable and to make the working conditions manageable.

The importance of knowledge not aligning with their political strategies comes up as one important factor. One political advisor highlights the existence of multiple interpretations of knowledge, where it becomes the advisor's role to select if it fits their political narrative, by telling a history of a time when they had to decide on political priorities versus expertise from civil servants:

And we engaged with the Commission, civil servants from the Commission, who said that would be a very bad idea, according to them. Well, both told to us on a technical level and also to my MEP. And my MEP decided to continue pushing for the expansion of [...] because he believes that what the negative people have said are preventing this from being a good idea. [...] That's not because he necessarily distrusts them or their expertise, but he believes that they weigh something more heavily than he weighs it, and they weigh something less than he weighs [...] So as you see, the two sides just weigh different things more. Then it's my political action to kind of figure out who comes out on top [...] but it's not so much a looking at the facts and one, looking at the dress and calling it blue or gold or whatever it was. (Interview 3, Renew)

Another respondent tells a similar story of how they are the ones responsible for filtering out politically relevant information:

Usually I have a quite good feeling about what is politically relevant. So I give my MEP the information I consider relevant or of communicational importance. I don't spam them with the whole text. Sometimes I just copy and paste. (Interview 10, Greens)

In this sense, knowledge is only one input into the political craft. The MEP in this case decides the political strategy based on partisan political goals and the political advisor tells a story of how they are responsible of finding a way to make the politics happen even if the experts say that it is a bad idea. The political advisor is the actual actor to act according to the political priorities and make sure that the knowledge they get from different networks is filtered into political action according to these political priorities. If it does not fit their political priorities, the knowledge is filtered away.

At the same time, the mobilizing of knowledge is not only shaped by political priorities but also by individual strategy to make the material usable technically. Several respondents describe how expertise first has to be filtered and translated into a form that is technically understandable and politically manageable for the MEP. One respondent describes this as a “first filter,” where the political advisor evaluates how much technical detail is relevant and understandable for the MEP before presenting it: “You have to know how much your MEP understands, and then you digest and bring down the information to the most salient political-technical points” (Interview 3, Renew). In this sense, mobilizing knowledge also involves transforming complex technical expertise into politically usable information.

This translation process becomes especially important in highly technical policy areas. Political advisors explain that technical complexity often requires them to seek additional expertise from researchers, universities, NGOs, or specialized actors outside the institutional structures. One respondent explains that “It becomes very technical [...] I have to call and ask those who actually have the figures” (Interview 8, S&D). Technical usability therefore functions as an

additional filtering mechanism, where political advisors not only decide what information is politically relevant, but also what information can realistically be transformed into actionable political knowledge under conditions of time pressure and informational complexity.

The strategic dimension of mobilizing knowledge also becomes visible in how respondents discussed the interpretation of knowledge. Several respondents emphasized that information and expertise are rarely viewed as fully objective, but rather as something that must be politically weighed and interpreted. This further amplified by another political advisor saying that “ [...] depending whether you like or not like the information you get... you are more or less likely to regard the information as neutral” (Interview 2, EPP). Another political advisor says that “If the information that we get is not aligned with what we want, you kind of have to find a common ground.” (Interview 12, Renew). One respondent explained:

But for us, what's very important is anything that's scientifically based. That's how we see how policy should be made. [...] But the thing is, science is inherently subjective. It's never fully objective, which means that no matter how objective they are trying to be, there's always going to be a bias. So if that bias is the same as yours, it's mostly going to confirm what you think. And if it's the other way around, it's probably just going to go against that. So you always have to take it with a grain of salt. (Interview 11, Renew)

Knowledge is not only filtered out but also actively used to strengthen political arguments. This is illustrated in the following example:

We did not know how much money was spent in the last Multiannual Financial Framework, MFF, for [...] We asked the European Parliament Research Service, EPRS, for a study. [...] They provided an estimate [...] of the MFF, which became the first available figure. This was important because I used it to gain leverage in discussions with the Commission and colleagues in the European Parliament. (Interview 7, S&D)

Here again the political advisor is put into the center of mobilizing information to make sure they fit with partisan goals. Neutrality becomes the weapon for knowledge that you can use to amplify your political goals, and if it does not fit with your political goals, the knowledge received is no longer seen as neutral information and something you can filter out.

5.3. Institutional legitimacy and norms

This chapter examines how institutional legitimacy and norms shape political advisors' ability to mobilize and use knowledge in EU policymaking. Bureaucratic structures shape access to and the content of expertise, showing that the way the European Parliament shapes its work creates a norm and legitimacy that do not value the usage of knowledge in policymaking. Several respondents describe a broader institutional shift away from knowledge-based policy making. One political advisor argues that fewer policy proposals are now grounded in formal expertise or evidence:

[...] it is frustrating that there are decisions taken on unclear grounds or without any factual basis [...] Before this mandate period the commission had as a rule that they created Impact Assessments, thorough assessments on policy proposals, and this has not been done this mandate period. A lot of bills are proposed without basis or scientific expertise. And it is very frustrating that our negotiations are lacking a basis to make proper decision. I would say that the bigger issue is the lack of information, rather than faulty information by civil servants [...] (Interview 6, Greens)

This respondent refers to the European Commission's former use of "Impact Assessments" which evaluated the economic, social or environmental impacts of a proposals during the period 2016- 2024 (European Commission, n.d.). The removal is here perceived as a part of politics and institutional norms that move away from evidence-based policymaking, suggesting that political advisors increasingly work within norms where expertise is less central and less institutionally legitimized in the policy making process. Impact assessments are not seen as a legitimate way of conducting policy making. This risks contributing to a norm of structural lack of expertise in decision-making in the European Parliament.

However, respondents show different norms and legitimacy in the need for assessments and scientific-based policymaking. While some view a lack of knowledge as a risk for the policies put out, others question the trust in the knowledge provided by civil servants. While not claiming explicit bias, the political advisor notes a general presumption that they do not really use input by the civil servants by saying that “we don’t really base our work on their work” (Interview 5, ECR). As illustrated above, where Interview 6 (Greens) is frustrated with there being less information in the policy making, the effects of one side viewing the civil service as less neutral can lead to political advisors skipping their input in the legislative phase. Overall, this suggests that varying levels of trust in civil servants influence how and to what extent their expertise is considered in the policymaking process. This shifts interpretative responsibility to political advisors, reinforcing their role as key actors who must navigate uncertainty and transform expertise into politically usable knowledge under constrained conditions.

Others are not that critical in their responses but points out a bureaucratic culture at the Parliament and Commission where the civil servants do not dare to give information and share knowledge that would go against the general norms and in order to maintain institutional neutrality:

[...] because they are afraid that they will be blamed for being political and choosing one party line over the other one. So they don't like to give you information that's 100% clear. [...]. And people will be like, who wrote this stupid law? Well, when politicians wrote it, the civil service was too scared to tell them that it was crap. (Interview 4, S&D).

These institutional constraints affect how knowledge is communicated. Civil servants may avoid giving clear recommendations to maintain “neutrality”, and instead push political advisors into informal channels in order to gain information:

As I said, there is a bureaucratic order which sometimes is very strict [...] I mean that maybe you are not allowed to give out information formally, but you have been allowed to inform about it informally so that I would say that there is a lot of information that goes in that way, which maybe is not just positive but it feels like it often becomes that way in these types of organizations too, so, but it is just like everyone leaks like the Commission. (Interview 1, Renew)

These accounts indicate that institutional norms surrounding neutrality and hierarchy shape not only what knowledge is communicated, but also how it is communicated. Formal structures may limit direct and explicit guidance from civil servants, leading advisors to rely more heavily on informal networks and unofficial information flows.

Political advisors also describe procedural barriers that make formal channels slow and restrictive. One respondent explains how even formal channels slow and restrictive. One respondent explains how even submitting questions to the Commission can become administratively difficult:

Maybe when you ask a question to the Commission, for example, very often it can become inadmissible because of how the question was formulated or because there are two sub-questions in one section, or they don't want to move forward the question to the Commission. Even after let's say a month or something since you sent it, because they say there has already been an answer to one of the sub-questions and they ask whether we would like to rephrase it or delete it instead of sending it. So it delays the process and I think what happens there, it delays the process and then someone can forget about already having sent it [...] (Interview 5, ECR)

These kinds of administrative obstacles in how you ask questions and the civil servant's interpretation of the question is brought up as a problem many times. Hierarchical communication structures, particularly within the Commission, further limit direct access, with

one respondent underlining that “But it is just like that, they need a number of days or weeks [...] to answer” (Interview 11, Renew). These delays become important because political advisors often work under significant time pressure. If advisors cannot access relevant expertise quickly enough, other information channels and actors may instead shape the policymaking process.

In line with the theoretical framework, respondents consistently describe working under conditions of time pressure and information overload. Political advisors receive large amounts of information from institutions such as the Commission and the European Parliamentary Research Service, making filtering a necessary part of their role. As one advisor explains, “We receive hundreds of emails a day [...] we have to filter what is relevant” (Interview 7, S&D). Under these conditions, filtering becomes both a political and practical necessity. Advisors must reduce complexity before passing information on to their MEPs, while also prioritizing information that is accessible and usable. One respondent captures this dynamic by explaining: “I cannot flood him with information” (Interview 4). Expertise therefore competes for attention alongside input from NGOs, lobbyists, and other actors, reinforcing the advisor’s role as a gatekeeper of information.

Overall, this subchapter demonstrates that political advisors’ filtering practices are shaped not only by time pressure and information overload, but also by institutional norms, bureaucratic procedures, and varying levels of trust in expertise. Formal channels are often perceived as slow or restrictive, encouraging reliance on informal information flows, while skepticism toward institutional neutrality further affects how expertise is interpreted and used. Consequently, political advisors do not merely transmit knowledge within EU policymaking; they actively navigate institutional constraints and transform expertise into politically usable knowledge under conditions of uncertainty.

5.4. Relational trust

In this chapter, focus will lay on the relational trust and informality in the networks in parliament. Informal flows of information and knowledge reach political advisors through informal relations with civil servants and contacts with lobbyist and NGOs. A central theme across the interviews is that trust in civil servant’s knowledge is constructed relationally rather

than institutionally. This would not necessarily be in opposition to the fact that there are institutional norms that affect the mobilizing of knowledge, just that there are different norms at the same time.

One respondent stress that personal relationships help a lot in finding and mobilizing the right knowledge:

[...] some civil servants, you know them personally, which also helps. [...] before they were a civil servant, they were in your political group or also working as an upper or as a political advisor from your group, et cetera. So that even helps you a bit or benefits because they also know which direction you want to go [...] (Interview 2, EPP).

This quotation lays out the premises for this whole chapter. Certain informational benefits will come to those political advisors who know civil servants personally. Here it is pointed out that if you have worked together before in a setting, they would know what a political advisor needs when asking for expertise. This is further highlighted by another respondent who highlights familiarity with the civil servants as a key factor in receiving trustworthy information: “It sometimes depends on interpersonal relationships [...] whether you know somebody, we've worked with them before, whether the information they have given you before is trustworthy” (Interview 3, Renew). Trust is brought forward here. The question about relational information is not just about knowing who and what to ask for to get the best information, it is also about retaining information that the political advisor can have trust in. If there is trust put into the knowledge given, they will mobilize it.

This kind of relational trust is frequently described as rooted in shared national, regional, or political contexts. Political advisors describe how input is often drawn primarily from familiar environments: “It is first and foremost national representations and their expertise [...] we listen and prioritize the input that comes from their regional government offices” (Interview 1, Renew). Even though there are civil services in the European Parliament, a political advisor describes the frequent use of government offices from their national context instead. Shared

cultural or linguistic backgrounds can also facilitate communication: “When I ask a scientific question, I usually ask it to someone who has worked in the same region, because then I get exactly what I asked for” (Interview 1, Renew).

Beyond national ties, networks also form around policy areas. Political advisors explain that “if you work on very specific topics, you tend to have a network of people working on those topics” (Interview 12, Renew), and that “it's mostly informal contacts [...] if you know someone, you can reach out” (Interview 4, S&D).

Trust is also shaped by perceptions of personal characteristics and professional background. Political advisors highlight differences in communication styles, organizational norms, and responsiveness, which affect how expertise is received and evaluated. Cultural differences can influence clarity and efficiency, sometimes leading to misunderstandings or delays (Interview 1, Renew).

A professional background is also important for perceived credibility. Many civil servants are seen as valuable because of their prior experience: “these are people who've worked in ministries, agencies [...] sometimes they've worked in the private sector” (Interview 3, Renew). Such backgrounds signal competence and familiarity with policy processes, making their expertise more trustworthy. Political advisors, therefore, assess expertise not only based on institutional role, but also on their network and trust in the civil servants' experiences.

Trust is further reinforced through repetitive experiences with the civil servants. Political advisors emphasize that credibility develops over time as information is verified through previous exchanges: “You have worked with them for a long time, you already have verified the information, and from that point on you are more likely to trust the information. It's relationship building” (Interview 10, Greens). Because the number of relevant actors is limited, political advisors often repeatedly interact with the same individuals: “there's not that many, and therefore you tend to talk to the same people” (Interview 3, Renew). As another respondent notes, “the more you're working here, the more you know the actors. So, this is really important, just time” (Interview 7, S&D).

These relationships frequently extend beyond formal institutional channels and rely heavily on informal exchanges. It is emphasized that “it is really in the informal contact that you get information” (Interview 6, Greens), often through closed-door conversations where actors speak more openly, but “never in writing” (Interview 7, S&D). Informal relationships can even become personal: “You can also get information from civil servants from the Commission, because sometimes they are friends” (Interview 7, S&D). Trust may also be reinforced when actors share overlapping interests, as:

I would say that the best information you obviously get when there's also something in it for the civil servant, for the counterpart. When they see we have overlapping interests, it's therefore also in their interest to help me. (Interview 14, Renew).

Importantly, these networks extend across institutional boundaries, including the Commission and other EU bodies, where informal relationships sometimes bypass formal channels entirely (Interview 7, S&D).

However, this is not uncontested. Some respondents note that informal channels do not matter that much in mobilizing knowledge. It is more about the bureaucratic rules and how trust is facilitated than the informal channels and retaining information that way. As one respondent argues: “the quality of information you get is regardless of the nationality of the person [...] it's just a matter how you communicate” (Interview 2, EPP). The way you ask a question is, in this case, more determining of what input you will get and if you can mobilize that knowledge into politics. Another respondent emphasizes this by saying, “It is more often that EU bureaucrats have their own culture, for better or worse. [...] you notice that different civil servants are different people. This could have to do with nationality [...] but rather it has to do with cultures at the different institutions [...]” (Interview 6, Greens).

And this culture is brought forward a few times, often as something that makes the political advisors not trust the civil service and the knowledge provided by them. One respondent lifts forward that there is a trend right now, and says that “Most of the time when you receive the

document from the civil servants, you know it's science-based. It's getting worse and worse, but it's serious stuff [...]" (Interview 7, S&D), underlining that there is still trust in the civil servants, but there is some kind of trust being dismantled here. The same goes for the following quotation:

[...] generally our presumption is that civil servants of Parliament, the bureaucrats, they are usually more supportive of what we see it [...] to the liberal left-leaning groups. But this is my perspective. [...] I cannot say they are liberals or not but I just feel like whenever somebody from the of the right-wing groups does something they are more likely to be punished or held accountable than someone from the other side of the groups [...]
(Interview 5, ECR)

This perception contributes to a more cautious engagement with institutional expertise, as political advisors may question whether it fully reflects their political or national priorities. Institutional expertise was analyzed earlier in this chapter, but here another perspective comes up. The rather individual perspective that relational trust is a part of a broader institutional norm. If there is a general disbelief against civil servants by the political advisors from the whole political spectrum, the actors that might interact the most with civil servants from the political side, might facilitate a stronger disbelief in the whole institution and knowledge-based policy making. The distrust in civil servants that some of the respondents might be showing, even if there is a small amount of it, risks contributing to a dismantling of the formal knowledge networks, such as the impact assessments as described in the former subchapter.

This is important to bring forward, as it shows a general trend moving toward political advisors placing disbelief in civil service and not using their knowledge and advice in the preparatory work of policy-making. The general belief in the interviews is that this kind of distrust is attributed to only the right-wing political staff, exemplified by one political advisor saying that: "I assume the progressive side places a lot of trust in the institutions. I believe the far right mistrusts institutions. [...]" (Interview 10, Greens). While the respondents more generally show a trend where political advisors from the ECR, for example, have more distrust in the civil

service, the political advisor exemplified above comes from S&D, and also shows growing distrust in the civil service.

This subchapter shows that trust in knowledge is primarily structured through three mechanisms: shared contextual backgrounds, perceived personal and professional characteristics, and accumulated experience through repeated interaction over time. These mechanisms are intertwined and reinforce each other, making access to knowledge relational and unevenly distributed. Political advisors seem to mobilize the knowledge coming this way more than that coming from official channels. Rather than relying on formal institutional hierarchies, political advisors depend on informal networks. At the same time, a growing disbelief towards civil services is shown, compromising the bureaucracy that is put there to ensure a science-based approach in policy making, and in the end seems to make political advisors mobilize less of the knowledge coming from civil servants.

5.5. Other factor: Multiple knowledge claims

Beyond the predefined analytical categories, the material reveals a broader pattern in how political advisors engage with knowledge: they mobilize knowledge coming from outside of the institution when ordinary knowledge claims do not function. As a result of the growing disbelief in civil service in the institutions, there seems to be a growing trend in how political advisors consistently draw on a wide range of external actors, including NGOs, industry, think tanks, and scientific institutions. As one respondent explains, they like to read:

Industry report, NGO report, and [...] I do like to read scientific studies. To be fair, time is short and scientific studies, if they are not exactly on the topic, are very often only covering a part of [...] But NGOs have very often, but also industry, specific knowledge on the topic [...] (Interview 9, Greens)

This duality is accompanied by systematic cross-checking practices, where information is validated across actors: “you double source it, checking that information with somebody in that field” (Interview 10, Greens). In this sense, expertise is not simply consumed, but continuously compared across sources within the filtering process.

This environment is reinforced by high volumes of incoming information, which require active filtering. One advisor describes receiving “thousands of thousands of emails” from campaigns, NGOs, and institutional actors, all of which must be sorted to distinguish relevance and underlying interests (Interview 7, S&D). As a result, advisors are constantly exposed to competing interpretations of the same issue, making expertise less a determining factor in itself and more a matter of prioritisation within the filtering process. In this context, institutional sources such as EPRS are often valued precisely because they provide structured overviews, described as offering a “comprehensive overview” (Interview 9, Greens) and “quite objective” input (Interview 10, Greens).

Political advisors, therefore, position themselves as mediators between competing epistemic claims. Civil servants are described to provide “factual information,” but this is constantly weighed against civil society and industry perspectives, requiring what one respondent describes as “finding the balance” between different inputs (Interview 12, Renew).

6. Discussions and conclusions

This chapter aims to discuss and conclude this thesis. It first provides a discussion part to summarize the paper, underline the theoretical contributions, as well as underscoring areas for further research and policy implications. Lastly, concluding remarks will be given.

This thesis has examined how political advisors to Members of the European Parliament mobilize knowledge in the process of policy formation. The analysis provides new insight into how and why expertise is practically mobilized into political action by those who work the most with the political project from the beginning. More broadly, the study shows that knowledge does not enter policymaking as a neutral input, but is mobilized through strategic, institutional, and relational mechanisms. The findings will be discussed in this chapter, and further research areas and policy implications will be disclosed.

This chapter aims to give an answer to this paper's research question: How do political advisors who work for Members of the European Parliament mobilize knowledge from civil servants in the stages of policy formation?

6.1. Discussion of findings

The study demonstrates that political advisors actively mobilize knowledge through filtering processes before information reaches their MEPs. Knowledge rarely enters policymaking unprocessed. Instead, political advisors assess what information is strategically relevant, manageable under conditions of time pressure and information overload and trustworthy. This study develops three perspectives on how the political advisors do so. They consistently describe how they are more likely to mobilize knowledge when it supports or can be adapted to fit political or individual goals. If knowledge does not align with partisan priorities, it is often not prioritized and overlooked, or filtered out completely when giving briefings or reports to their MEP. They may proceed against expert recommendations because their role is to determine which information is workable and then mobilize that knowledge. Ultimately, the importance of knowledge depends on its political usefulness.

In this sense, the study develops previous studies by showcasing how political advisors do this in practice through everyday work processes. Political advisors not only pass on knowledge from civil servants but also transform it into politically usable forms, with different degrees of autonomy in this process. Importantly, the study shows that regardless of the degree of

autonomy, all advisors participate in the filtering of knowledge, making this a universal feature of the role rather than an individual variation. It is not only politicians that shape knowledge and information into political actions, as deemed in previous research and theory (Blom, 2020; Marshall, 2012), political advisors also mobilize the knowledge into political action.

Additionally, the findings demonstrate that this filtering process is embedded in institutional and relational contexts. Political advisors in the European Parliament rely on personal networks, repeated collaboration, and perceived credibility of providers when deciding what knowledge to mobilize. They show that the more trust put into the knowledge provider, the more is the likelihood of them viewing it as legitimate and mobilizing that knowledge and turn it into political action. Crucially, this does not mean that just because there is trust put into civil servants, the political advisors tend to listen to them more. To find out if that is the case, a results-based study needs to be conducted to really understand if the degree of trust affects the outcomes and if there is causality. But, it shows that when there is trust in actors, political advisors tend to receive more information and knowledge from civil servants and at least listen to the claims more.

However, it suggests a gradual shift in this. Several political advisors describe a perceived decline in institutional trust and changing practices within the Parliament, including concerns about reduced reliance on formal tools such as impact assessments for policy proposals. Increasing polarization and a stressful work environment may at times override knowledge procedures, creating greater skepticism toward institutional knowledge. This suggests that the legitimacy of knowledge may be becoming more conditional and politically contested, where expertise is increasingly evaluated not only on procedural credibility but also on its perceived political relevance. Political advisors may have less knowledge now due to this decline and skepticism toward institutional knowledge. While several patterns appeared consistently across respondents, there were indications that this seeking of knowledge externally, because of a decrease in trust in the civil servants, may vary across political and ideological contexts. Due to the limited number of interviews, this study cannot draw broader conclusions regarding the differences between the ideologies and the European party group. Future research should therefore examine more systematically whether ideological positioning influences how political advisors mobilize knowledge from civil servants compared to external actors such as NGOs, industry representatives, think tanks, or party networks. Comparative studies across political

groups, committees, or national delegations could further contribute to understanding how expertise becomes politically actionable within EU policymaking. This study can still determine that there is a growing skepticism against the knowledge provided by the civil servants.

Ultimately, this leads to an additional mobilizing mechanism that was not previously discovered in the theoretical framework. Political advisors frequently rely on relations with sources outside of the institutions, including NGOs, industry, and scientific institutions. The knowledge provided by these external actors is described as something they double-check against information provided by the civil servants. This develops the theory of knowledge utilization, as it shows that when the ordinary levels of knowledge mobilization do not work, meaning that when it takes a long time for civil servants to provide information or when the political advisors do not trust the civil service, they go outside the legitimacy provided by their institution to seek information. They replace the ordinary knowledge providers with new ones. While some of the political advisors problematize the lobbyists' access to them, most of the political advisors talk about the lobbyists sending them reports and studies, just like any other knowledge service provided. The lobbyists' access is treated just like any other knowledge provider in the European Parliament, showcasing that there are different knowledge claims in the Parliament.

The study carries broader policy implications regarding transparency and access to expertise in EU governance. As discussed above, the findings demonstrate that informal relationships and personal trust play a central role in determining which knowledge is considered credible and usable in policymaking, as well as networks outside of the EU institutions. This raises questions regarding transparency and democratic accountability within the European Parliament. Institutional reforms focused solely on formal transparency on lobbying between politicians and lobbyists, as the Transparency register, where lobbyists who seek to affect and influence politicians must sign a code of conduct (European Union, n.d.), risk not fulfilling its purpose as the lobbyists are not required to do so when meeting a political advisor. This is important due to the fact that political advisors seem to increasingly place more trust in external actors and their knowledge claims, which gives them easy access to affect policymaking under the radar from the Transparency register. The increased trust in external actors also places a lot of

accountability on the political party groups and national parties to keep their political staff accountable.

There is also a policy implication in the form of the institutions' responsibility in providing efforts to keep the institutional trust and legitimacy in the civil service. Since there are perceptions of politicization within the civil service as well as an identified increasing distrust in the civil servants and the knowledge they provide, there needs to be policy efforts aimed at safeguarding impartiality and transparency within EU institutions. This may therefore be important not only for legitimacy, but also for ensuring that institutional knowledge can continue to function as a trusted resource within policymaking processes in the future.

6.2 Concluding remarks

This paper has tried to confirm and extend previous research portraying political advisors as influential actors in EU policymaking, especially in early policy formation. This thesis shows how these roles operate through the mobilizing of expertise in everyday networks with civil servants, and what has come up during the interviews, including additional external actors. Knowledge is not transmitted neutrally but interpreted within institutional norms of legitimacy, political strategies, and relationships. The analysis demonstrates that political advisors actively shape which knowledge becomes politically actionable and which is filtered out due to norms, strategies or trust. As a result, they occupy a central position in connecting expertise and knowledge with political decision-making in the European Parliament. In this sense, the thesis develops previous research by showing not only that political advisors are influential actors, but also how this influence is exercised in practice through the mobilization of expertise. By conceptualizing political advisors as “knowledge mobilizers,” the thesis also extends research on knowledge utilization into a new institutional and political context, showing how knowledge becomes politically actionable through their practices and through how they tend to mobilize more and more knowledge from external actors.

Our global challenges are seen as something that needs to be fixed by our elected representatives. But when there is a group of non-elected officials who get to decide what gets brought to the table and whatnot, one cannot help but feel a distance from the policymaking machine. This study has tried to examine what guides this group of people in their work and come up with a mix of answers: political strategies, personal relationships, trust in civil service

and lobbyists, and institutional norms. If we want to strengthen accountability and bridge this distance, the European Parliament needs to set up systems so that external powers do not exert influence on its policy-making. As well as the political parties and the party groups that need to take responsibility and accountability for their unelected staff. Lastly, the European Parliament has a responsibility in making sure that knowledge claims are mobilized in policy-making, regardless of whether it fits political goals or not.

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